

Looking at the actual figures broken down that way, I can't believe how much money I spend in both checking and on credit cards. When I never had more than \$500 in my bank account at once, I couldn't fathom that I'd spend \$65 on clothing and not even notice. Or that my rent would be so casually past the thousands. (In NYC, I struggled to find places under \$800 every time I moved because I could not afford to go above that; in fact, I could barely afford that. In Boston, my rent limit was \$500.) Or that I'd pay for two movies on Amazon in one week and then never watch either of them.

After studying these figures, I decided not to create a monthly budget for myself. I know that, like Suze Orman suggested, I won't stick to it long term. Instead, at my girlfriend's suggestion, I downloaded two apps: One is called Digit, which is a mix between a budgeting app and a savings app. I created different funds to save for different expenses, and then every day, Digit takes a dollar or a few cents, depending on how much money I have, out of my account and slips it into one of these funds. I hardly notice the missing pennies.

While it's not a huge, strict overhaul like Ramsey would suggest, going through my bank account and looking at what I spend on did motivate me to separate my extraneous expenses into these smaller accounts. When I need money for a haircut, for instance, I can look at my haircut account and see if I can afford it. This has been a huge help. Budgeting, like all other things money, isn't one size fits all. So let's look at some of the different ways people budget.

BUDGETING THEORIES

CASH ONLY. In 2017, writer Kathleen Elkins did an eight-week “cash diet” that consisted of surviving on \$60 a week (for anything other than rent and bills). She wrote about it for CNBC in January, offering her tips on budgeting: (1) Track all your spending in an Excel spreadsheet, (2) cook your own food and stop drinking alcohol out—or, hell, quit drinking altogether, (3) set a specific numbered goal so that when you spend \$5 on a whim, you can know that's \$5 less to spend on something else, and (4) socialize without spending tons of money. (It took me YEARS to realize I could hang out with friends at bars